

Beware of phishing apps that load ransomware trojans

Web and mobile applications that track the spread of the Covid-19 virus outbreak are also loading ransomware trojans and trackers to snoop on users, according to cyber security firms. For instance, some map-based applications that trace the path of the virus across the globe could end up infecting a user's phone with a virus.

According to information security provider ZScaler, hackers are now floating applications on the Internet that claim to notify a user as soon as anyone infected with the virus is nearby. What such apps do instead is lock out the user and ask for ransoms to unlock their device. "There are also apps that tell you where you can go and buy an N-95 mask. These are all hoaxes—the moment a user downloads such an app it will corrupt your smartphone or laptop and may ask for a ransom to unlock it," said Sudip Banerjee, director, Transformation Strategy - Asia Pacific and Japan at ZScaler. Such apps are not available on popular application

download platforms such as Google Play and App Store but can be downloaded from websites.

On its developer blog, Apple said "We are evaluating apps critically to ensure data sources are reputable and that developers presenting these apps are from recognised entities such as government organisations, health-focused NGOs, companies deeply credentialed in health issues, and medical or educational institutions." The threat, however, is not limited to applications. Phishing scams are also capitalising on the topicality of the virus. Mails are sent offering a clickable document that allegedly includes a list of precautions to take to prevent infection, but these documents can be unsafe.

Check for and delete emails from unexpected sources, said Chester Wisniewski, principal research scientist at cybersecurity firm Sopho. "The best approach to avoid this type of cyberattack is to turn off macros, be extra cautious about what you click, and delete email that is suspicious or from an unexpected source."

BSNL offering free Internet for one month

To help people work from home, study at home, or just get entertained during the novel coronavirus outbreak in India, Bharat Sanchar Network India (BSNL), a government of India enterprise, is offering free Internet for one month to its landline telephone customers. In case someone doesn't have BSNL connection, the telecom operator will install it free, including the copper wire for connection. You just need to purchase a modem/router from them.

After one month, the users will have to select a paid plan of their choice. Those opting for high-speed fibre broadband line will have to pay for the fibre-optic cable's installation. Existing BSNL customers can simply call the customer service for the Internet connection.



Representational image

Industry 4.0 survey results announced



Representational image

In a study done in India on 'Will the next transformation in manufacturing be led by Digital?' by Ernst & Young, two-thirds of the 50 large manufacturing firms contacted have identified Big Data and Predictive Analytics as the top investment priority technologies for next couple of years. However, 66 per cent of the respondents were also unclear about the economic benefits from digital investments, indicating they were yet to catch up with concepts such as Industry 4.0 and Smart Factories.

Major hurdles identified in the study for moving to the digital world included, (a) deficiency in people's skills on tech, analytics, cybersecurity, etc, (b) lack of understanding of the impact of digital manufacturing, and (c) insufficient tech infrastructure in terms of hardware and software. It was found, however, that 49 per cent of the firms were in the process of enhancing their digital infrastructure (hardware and software) and workforce by providing training. And, 63 per cent already had some infrastructure in place with basic software data capture and process monitoring.